

SCENE I: Childhood

[The stage is set in a Filipino neighborhood in Tagaytay. A large tree dominates stage right, its branches extending over part of the playing area. Downstage center, children are playing traditional games. The festival rehearsal setup remains minimal - just a few portable decorations and props ready to be brought in. Late afternoon lighting suggests the golden hour.]

CARLOS:

(running while looking back, almost tripping)

You're never gonna catch me, Alejandro! Your aim is as bad as your lola's eyesight!

ALEJANDRO (AJ):

(picking up his slipper)

Hey! Leave my lola out of this! She makes the best sinigang in all of Tagaytay!

CARLOS:

(laughing)

Haha, that's true though! Remember when she caught us stealing mangoes from her tree?

AJ:

(aiming his slipper)

Instead of getting mad or scolding us, she made us climb up and pick more!

(throws the slipper, knocking down the can)

CARLOS:

(dramatically falling to his knees)

Ah! The champion Alejandro strikes again! I surrender to you master of tumbang preso!

AJ:

(helping CARLOS up)

Get up, you drama king! You're worse than those teleseryes my mama watches!

[They move to sit under the tree, their laughter fading into silence. Other kids continue playing in the background.]

CARLOS:

(picking at grass)

You know what Dad told me yesterday? He said childhood friends are like the roots of this old tree. Even when you can't see them, they're always connected.

AJ:

My lola says something very similar, something about pamana. She still meets her childhood friends every Sunday after church. They're all so old now but they laugh like they're still kids.

CARLOS:

(looking up at the branches)

Do you think we'll be like that? When we're old and growing gray hairs?

AJ:

(playfully punching CARLOS's shoulder)

Well of course! But you'll be the one going bald first!

[The school bell chimes. MARIO enters, carrying traditional coconut shells for Maglalatik.]

MARIO:

Hoy, psst! Halika dito, anak! **[Come here!]** Time for rehearsal!

[Students line up. MR. CONCEPCION and MARIO help attach coconut shells to their bodies and chests.]

MR. CONCEPCION:

Before we begin, let's all thank Carlos's dad, Tito Mario, for assisting us with our performance. Now, does anyone want to share why we perform Maglalatik?

AJ:

(eagerly raising his hand)

My lolo told me! It's about how our ancestors fought over coconut meat during fiestas!

CARLOS:

Like how you would fight over the last piece of lechon at my birthday party...

MR. CONCEPCION:

Carlos, that's enough. Very good, AJ! The dance shows us that even conflicts can turn into celebration. The coconuts we clash together? They make music instead of war.

CARLOS:

(struggling with his coconut shell straps)

Tay, can you help me put these on? These keep coming loose.

MARIO:

(fixing CARLOS's straps)

There, anak. Now you won't accidentally launch these into Principal Bautista's face.

(ruffles CARLOS's hair)

CARLOS:

(whiney)

That was ONE time, Tay.

MR. CONCEPCION:

Places everyone! Remember, Maglalatik is about precision and partnership. Watch your partner's movements. Feel the rhythm together.

[The dance begins. CARLOS and AJ face each other, coconut shells clacking in rhythm. Though they occasionally miss a beat, their recovery is seamless because they watch out for each other.]

CARLOS:

(during a synchronized move)

Left, right, up...wait, which is my left again?

AJ:

Follow my lead. From what I saw, its knees, chest, back, hips. You follow?

CARLOS & AJ:

Knees, chest, back, hips, knees, chest, back, hips...

[The music for maglalatik swells in the background as Carlos and AJ practice together. AJ and CARLOS exit off stage]

----- **MAGLALATIK performs** -----

AJ:

(still catching his breath)

You know what's funny? When we first learned this dance, you were so scared of hitting the shells too hard.

CARLOS:

Because I didn't want to hurt you! Unlike someone who kept whacking my knuckles...

AJ:

(laughing)

Hey, I was teaching you to be tough! Besides, you got better. We both did.

CARLOS:

(becoming serious)

AJ...about what you said earlier. About getting older? One day, will you forget about all this? About the dance, our games ...about me?

AJ:

(turning to face CARLOS)

Never. You know why? Because *(looks for and acknowledges tree)* you're like this tree. No matter how old I grow, I'll always know where my roots are. After all, you're my best friend.

CARLOS:

Pinky promise?

AJ:

(holding out his pinky)

More than a promise. Kasunduan na ito. [TRANSLATION: "*this is an agreement*"] An agreement between hearts.

[They carve their names into the tree and pinky promise. The stage lights dim slightly, focusing on their silhouettes under the tree as festival sounds continue in the background.]

CARLOS:

Salamat, AJ.

AJ:

Para saan?

CARLOS:

For being you. For being here. For everything.

[They sit in silence as the lights slowly fade, the festival continues as a distant murmur, and the tree stands sentinel over their friendship.]

—— TPV performs PANALANGIN ——

SCENE II: High School

[The stage opens on a garden outside of a school., REYNA, LENA, and BENJI are picking flowers in preparation for the bulaklakan performance.]

[BENJI spins with the basket in his hand, causing a few to spill out]

LENA:

(ducking)

Ay nako, Benji, be gentle! We want these flowers to look good for the bulaklakan performance. We aren't little kids anymore.

BENJI:

Just perfecting my twirl, in case one of you gets sick

REYNA:

Please. You couldn't possibly think you can pull off the Bulaklakan dress. It's like putting lipstick on a pig.

BENJI:

At least I don't eat like a pig

LENA:

Okay, enough, you two. Just pick up the flowers while we wait for AJ and Carlos to get back.

REYNA:

It's always those two going off on their own.

BENJI:

Like that time we went to Mall of Asia in elementary. AJ wanted to get a drink and Carlos just had to join him...

LENA:

Shh.. they're coming.

[CARLOS and AJ enter. CARLOS greets BENJI and REYNA. AJ gives his basket to LENA. EVERYONE meets on the bench.]

LENA:

Thank you for finally getting the flowers, you two.

AJ:

We're sorry for being late; someone kept breaking them in half while collecting them.

CARLOS:

Some flower expert you are—always receiving so many flowers.

AJ:

You're one to talk, pogi boy.

CARLOS:

If I'm pogi boy, then you're guapito.

BENJI:

And if you're guapito, I guess that makes me, *(dramatically)* Paquito.

LENA:

(stage whisper to REYNA)

Ten pesos says they're as oblivious as Benji.

REYNA:

(stage whisper back)

Twenty pesos says something dramatic has to happen before one of them makes a move.

(shake on it, then go back to conversation)

CARLOS:

By the way, my Dad is supposed to pick me up after this. I don't think I can walk you home this time.

AJ:

That's fine, I already have plans after.

CARLOS:

(confused for a moment, but switches to joking)

Ah, is that why you got extra flowers?

BENJI:

Carlos, why are you always picking on AJ-(?)

LENA:

(pulling Benji away) Enough Benji. Well, Benji and I should head out before our mom gets home.

REYNA:

I'll head out with you two if you don't mind. *(stage whisper)* and give these two some space.

[REYNA, LENA, and BENJI walk off stage. LENA is scolding BENJI in the background.]

CARLOS:

So these plans after...? You didn't mention it. The one day I don't walk you home... You cheating on me?

AJ:

If you're so worried, calm down. It's just a stupid college event at De La Salle. *(modest)*

CARLOS:

Of course, the champion Alejandro always reaching for the stars. *(beat)* and me, right there to support you, I just don't know what's gonna happen in the future, I'm just a little lost...

AJ:

You know you can tell me anything right?

CARLOS:

I know, I just-

AJ:

You're my best friend, Carlos. If there's anything I know, its that we'll always have each other.

[They hug, silently coming to an agreement.]

CARLOS:

Salamat Alejandro—I don't know what I'd do without you.

AJ:

Don't worry, you'll never have to find out.

[Both smile]

ISABELLA:

KUYA, we're here na! Let's go!

[CARLOS and AJ are startled and quickly pull away. CARLOS walks toward his younger sister but takes a moment to look back at his friend. He sheepishly waves bye to AJ, and AJ acknowledges him back.]

----- **BULAKLAKAN performs** -----

SCENE III: University

MARIO:

Isabella, we got a letter from Kuya. Come.

Letter 1:

Tatay,

I hope you're well. It's the first day of university! And I wanted to write a letter to express how thankful I am for you. I can't imagine my childhood without you egging me on at elementary dance recitals or telling me how well I did in my maglalatik performances. It means a lot that you were there for me, and I promise to keep in touch while away from home. Please tell Isabella I love her and don't forget to pack her Chippy before school. I know she's older now, but just pretend like it's my little thing with her. You all mean so much to me, and I'm sorry I can't be there for everything happening back home. I love you, and I want to reassure you, while at college, with the help of Alejandro and the barkada, I promise I'll dedicate every night to studying.

How sweet. Now come help in the garden, Isabella.

----- MODERN performs -----

[Party music begins as the stage is filled with college freshmen. Loud conversation and dancing occur. CARLOS and AJ walk in relieved and loose.]

REYNA:

(dramatically collapsing onto a nearby chair)

Finally, freedom!

LENA:

Well, freedom ba talaga? [TRANSLATION: "Well, is it really freedom?"] These college readings are already killing me.

AJ:

(settling next to CARLOS with familiar ease)

Still better than high school. At least there are no Tinikling practices for Cultural Week for hours every day?

CARLOS:

(wincing and rubbing his shins)

Don't remind me! But still, I do kinda miss it.

[Before CARLOS can process this, BENJI rushes in.]

BENJI:

(acting like he's drunk)

MY BARKADAAAA! YOU MADE ITTTT! You've GOT to try the punch.

REYNA:

Are you okay? You look worse than AJ when he mistook a peanut for Boy Bawang.

LENA:

Sige, lay off the punch.

(grabs cup from Benji and supports his weight as BENJI lays on her)

What's even in this?

[PARTY HOST comes up between REYNA and LENA and charismatically puts his arms on their shoulders.]

CHAD:

(pushing drinks into the friend group's hands)

Welcome, freshies! Tonight's specials are *virgin* calamansi mojitos and my lola's secret recipe, halo-halo *mocktails*... Not sure what this guy had.

BENJI:

FREEDOMMMM!

CHAD:

Anyways, have fun, guys. Let loose a little, you only live once. *(winks)*

[The center stage lights transform into a dance floor atmosphere. The music shifts to "", creating an instant buzz of excitement.]

REYNA:

(moving everyone to the dance floor)

You heard him! Let's let loose! Come on!

[CARLOS and AJ join their friend group but keep finding themselves gravitating toward each other.]

CARLOS:

(attempting a complex dance move)

Still think you can out-dance me?

AJ:

(matching the move perfectly)

Always. But you're getting better.

[The music transitions to a slow song. The lights dim to a soft blue. Couples form while others drift away. CARLOS and AJ stand in their spot, caught in an uncertain moment.]

CARLOS:

(starting to step back)

I should probably...

AJ:

(reaching for CARLOS's hand)

Stay. Dance with me?

CARLOS:

(heart visibly racing)

Are you sure? People might...

AJ:

(pulling him closer)

People might what? See two friends who've always been there for each other? Who cares what they think?

[They begin to slow dance, maintaining a respectful distance at first. The background action dims, with a soft spotlight on them.]

CARLOS:

(voice slightly shaky)

Everything's different now. New school, new friends, new... everything. Sometimes I worry...

AJ:

(completing his thought)

That we'll drift apart? Carlos, look at me. Change is scary, pero hindi ibig sabihin na dapat tayong matakot. We shouldn't act scared. [TRANSLATION: "*but that doesn't mean we should be afraid*"]

CARLOS:

Since when did you become so wise?

AJ:

(grinning)

Someone has to balance out your dramatic tendencies.

[Their dance becomes more natural, closer, as they talk. The space between them shrinks with each turn. Their friends start to notice and step away.]

CARLOS:

(gathering courage)

Alejandro, can we talk about something deep?

(AJ nods)

AJ

Of course. I told you, you can tell me anything.

(CARLOS shyly and nervously turn his head away to avoid eye contact with AJ)

CARLOS:

I'm... (so very grateful for you and our friendship)

[ISABELLA bursts through their moment.]

ISABELLA:

Kuya! Something happened.

CARLOS:

Isabella. Are you okay? What's wrong? ("howd u get here ur not even supposed to be here" act more surprised)

ISABELLA:

It's Dad...

SCENE IV: Missed Confession

[The stage is set to reflect the warmth of a home, with a dining table set for dinner. CARLOS rushes in, looking for his father.]

CARLOS:

Where's dad?

ISABELLA:

(voice soft and somber)

He's in bed, I think. He's usually out in the garden at this time, but I think whatever's going on is taking a toll on him.

CARLOS:

This is starting to freak me out. Do you know what exactly happened to Dad?

ISABELLA:

(a tiny bit panicked and worried)

I told you, I don't even know. When he fainted, I took him straight to the hospital with Tita Elena, and then I went to get you. They brought him back today, but it's not good.

[CARLOS's face pales. He looks at his dad, who sits down beside him and holds his hand.]

CARLOS:

(stuttering)

What? What do you mean?

ISABELLA:

(sighs) I'll let Tay explain.

[MARIO enters on his cane and sits on the couch. CARLOS and ISABELLA quickly run toward their father and urge him to sit.]

CARLOS:

Tay! What happened? Are you okay?

MARIO:

Carlos, Isabella, come, come. I need to tell you both something.

[CARLOS and ISABELLA join their father on the couch. MARIO takes a deep breath]

I talked with the doctors, and I am okay. Carlos, I fainted yesterday while getting ready to go to lunch, and Isabella brought me to the hospital. I don't remember what happened next. Tita Elena said the doctors took X-rays, and that I might have a tumor... they don't have the supplies to provide full treatment if it gets worse. The best chance for full treatment is in America.

CARLOS:

America? That's on the other side of the world! Can't we get treatments here? What about Manila? Cebu? We don't have to leave...

ISABELLA:

Kuya, wait. The doctors said they looked into all possible treatments and plans. Right, Tay?

[ISABELLA looks to MARIO for affirmation. MARIO nods. pause; ISABELLA sighs in defeat and contention]

I already tried, Kuya. There's no other choice. We have to put Tay's health first.

[CARLOS stands abruptly, He paces around the room, running a hand through his hair.]

CARLOS:

This isn't fair! Everything I know is here—our home, our lives...my friends!

MARIO:

I know it's hard, Carlos. I'm sorry you have to make this sacrifice, I'm sorry we have to move with short notice. They said it's only going to get worse. And if I want more time with my kids, I need to get treatment asap.

[CARLOS's shoulders slump, the weight of the news sinking in. ISABELLA places a hand on his arm, but he pulls away.]

Sige, anak. I'll give you time to think. Your Tita Elena and Marvin said they have a cousin who can help us settle there. We can get you enrolled in a nice school. We can have a better life there.

(beat)

Isabella, can you help me move to my bed.

CARLOS:

(softly, almost to himself)

How am I supposed to leave everything behind?

[The lights go out. The backdrop changes to an open park at twilight. A bench sits stage right, and AJ is pacing around nervously, holding his phone. CARLOS enters stage left, his posture tense. AJ looks up and immediately notices something is wrong.]

AJ:

Carlos, what's going on? Everyone's been worried since you left the party.

[CARLOS hesitates, then sits on the bench. AJ follows, sitting beside him but giving him space.]

CARLOS:

Dad is sick. We have to move... It's all happening so fast. I've barely had any time to breathe.

AJ:

(nods in understanding)

I get it. At least you'll have your family when you move.

CARLOS:

But what about everything here, Alejandro? My life? My home? My friends? You?

[AJ reaches out, but CARLOS pulls away.]

CARLOS:

(voice breaking)

I feel like I'm losing everything all at once. We're leaving tomorrow, and no one even asked if I was ready!

AJ:

Carlos, I get it. This is huge, and it's unfair. But your dad needs you. You know that this has to come first.

CARLOS:

I know. I know he needs me. But leaving all of this behind...leaving...

[CARLOS looks at AJ, clearly on the verge of a confession, but stops himself.]

AJ:

Leaving what, Carlos?

CARLOS:

(after a moment, looking away)

Nothing. I just never thought I'd have to start over somewhere else.

[AJ studies CARLOS's face, sensing there's more he wants to say]

AJ:

Whatever it is, you can tell me. We've always been able to tell each other everything.

[CARLOS opens his mouth to speak, but is interrupted by the sound of familiar voices. BENJI, REYNA, and LENA enter from stage left, carrying small boxes]

BENJI:

(calling out)

There they are! I told you they'd be at their spot!

REYNA:

For once, you were actually right about something, Benji.

LENA:

We heard the news, Carlos. Isa told us everything.

[CARLOS looks grateful for the interruption but also disappointed at the lost moment with AJ.]

CARLOS:

(trying to smile)

You guys didn't have to come.

REYNA:

(scoffing)

Of course we had to come! Did you think we'd let you leave without a proper goodbye?

BENJI:

(holding out a small box)

We brought you something. So you don't forget us.

AJ:

(voice thick with emotion)

Guys...

[CARLOS opens. Inside is a pressed sampaguita flower from the tree they always sat under.]

LENA:

A piece of home to take with you.

BENJI:

(trying to lighten the mood)

And I included that embarrassing picture of you falling while dancing maglalatik. You know, just so you stay humble in America.

[They all laugh, though there's a hint of sadness]

REYNA:

(struggling to maintain composure)

We're going to miss you so much, Carlos. The barkada won't be the same without you.

CARLOS:

I'm going to miss all of you too. More than you know.

[The friends gather in a group hug, leaving CARLOS and AJ standing slightly apart afterward.]

BENJI:

(checking his watch)

We should probably go. Let you two have some alone time.

LENA:

(to CARLOS)

We'll see you tomorrow to drop you off at the airport?

CARLOS:

(nodding)

I'll be there

[REYNA, LENA, and BENJI exit, each giving CARLOS one last hug before leaving. CARLOS and AJ are alone again, the interrupted moment hanging between them.]

AJ:

(after a moment)

Carlos...will you ever come back?

[CARLOS looks at AJ, the weight of unspoken words between them.]

CARLOS:

(with determination)

I will. I don't know exactly when, but one day, I'll come back home. I promise.

AJ:

I'll be waiting.

[CARLOS and AJ grow closer. Faces about to touch.]

CARLOS:

(almost confessing)

Alejandro, I..

[CARLOS's phone rings. He checks it and sighs.]

CARLOS:

It's Isa. I have to go help pack before our flight tomorrow.

AJ:

Go. Your dad needs you.

CARLOS:

I'll see you tomorrow at the airport?

AJ:

I wouldn't miss it.

[CARLOS starts to leave, then turns back.]

CARLOS:

Alejandro... I... *(on the verge of confessing one final time)* I'm gonna miss you. Thank you. For everything.

[AJ nods, watching as CARLOS exits. The lights dim on AJ standing alone, touching the tree where they carved their initials years ago.]

AJ:

(to himself)

Hanggang sa muli, Carlos. **[TRANSLATION: “*See you again*”]** Until we meet again.

[The lights fade to black.]

(remove tree)

Bench becomes bed

Blanket

And bean bag

SCENE V: America

ISABELLA:

(wrapping her arms around herself, teeth chattering)

My God, Kuya! Three years in Chicago, and I still haven't gotten used to the weather.

CARLOS:

(taking off his jacket)

Here. Take it. I don't need it.

(he smiles to reassure her he's fine)

ISABELLA:

But you'll freeze to death!

CARLOS:

I'm fine. I'm your kuya, remember? Taking care of my little sister is my job.

ISABELLA:

Kuya, I'm 18, I can take care of myself.

MARIO:

(coughing softly as he wakes up but watching his children)

Mga anak. Is that you?

ISABELLA:

(quickly adjusting the blanket over her father's legs)

Tay, kumusta ka? Are you warm enough?

MARIO:

(reaching for both their hands)

With both of you here? How could I be cold?

(he laughs, then says nostalgically)

Naalala ko when you were little... back in the philippines... always climbing that mango tree behind our house...

ISABELLA:

(groaning but smiling)

Naku, Tay, not the mango tree story again!

MARIO:

Huy, you know, if it weren't for that mango tree, I wouldn't know your Tita Elena, your Tito Kevin de Ramos, your Ninong AJ, Ninong BJ, CJ –

ISABELLA:

Yes, yes, Tay; Ninongs A through Z J. How could I forget?

MARIO:

After we found that tree, our own barkada would visit it everyday. Share our feelings, our troubles. You know your Tito Kevin? Even when he moved to Cavite, he took a piece of the mango tree with him. It means he's carrying us wherever he goes. I haven't seen him in years but when I see you both playing under the tree, it reminds me of my own barkada. How even though we aren't together, we're connected by the memories that shape who we are.

CARLOS:

I remember.

MARIO:

(squeezing their hands)

You've always taken care of each other. Yan ang ibig sabihin ng pamilya.

[TRANSLATION: "*That's what family means*"]

Even in a new place... *(coughs)*

You're both still have each other.

CARLOS:

(respectfully and nostalgically)

I know, Tay. You taught me a lot. You remember when you dressed me up in coconuts for maglalatik? It was so much fun back then. With Mr. Concepcion, and my barkada, and...

MARIO:

With AJ?

CARLOS:

Yeah, with Alejandro. With everyone. With home

ISABELLA:

I miss the Philippines, I miss our home, Tay. *beat*

MARIO:

(thinks about how much he misses the Philippines)

Come closer, anak. Let me give you both a hug.

(They hug)

Isabella, how about you sing one of my classic favorites for me?

[ISABELLA begins softly, joined by CARLOS, then their father. The familiar melody of the Filipino lullaby fills the room.]

MARIO:

(barely above a whisper)

"Latara tara..."

[ISABELLA and CARLOS join their father in singing the lullaby, their voices carrying the melody as hers fades.]

----- TPV performs MAPA -----

SCENE VI: Nurse(ry)

[CARLOS stands in new scrubs. The bustling hospital environment is created through choreographed movement of the ENSEMBLE as nurses, doctors, and patients.]

CARLOS:

You've made it this far. Just breathe, Carlos. For Tatay.

[CARLOS bumps into DR. DE LA CRUZ, a familiar face amongst the controlled chaos.]

DR. DE LA CRUZ:

Carlos! Long time no see. Nice to see you finally in some scrubs.

CARLOS:

(In a tired voice yet still happy to see her)

Dr. De la Cruz!

(They hug)

It's nice to see a familiar face around here.

DR. DE LA CRUZ:

Don't worry, dear. We were all new once. How's the nursing gig?

CARLOS:

It's been good. The NCLEX was rough, but nice to be back in a familiar environment...

DR. DE LA CRUZ:

Yeah...

(The air of awkwardness around reconnecting settles; DR. DE LA CRUZ asks in an empathetic, concerned tone)

How have you been holding up? I haven't seen you and your sister since...

CARLOS:

Since my dad passed, hm? *(Beat)*

We've been good. Isabella's been attending Northwestern University for a couple years now; it looks like America isn't too new for her.

DR. DE LA CRUZ:

How nice to hear. Your family always seemed close, I hope you don't stray too far from home. Don't forget where you came from.

CARLOS:

Of course not.

(He smiles to her)

Thank you, Dr. De la Cruz.

(He checks his watch)

Oh my lunch break is over now. Nice to see you.

DR. DE LA CRUZ:

I was talking with a family and a nurse from the 3rd floor, and... they're a young couple. They were thinking of putting their child up for adoption.

CARLOS:

Oh, I see. Is there anything you need help with? Do you need me to connect to a social worker?

DR. DE LA CRUZ:

Well, you see, Carlos. I wanted to suggest you to the family. Both the parents are Filipino, and they were scared their child would grow up... without connecting to his roots. As you know, I'm old, and I already have three ma kulit kids in high school and college. You're the only other Filipino I know, and I remember what you told me about your sister... and your father. What do you think?

CARLOS:

I see. I'll think about it, Doctor. I just don't know if I'm ready to care for a kid.

DR. DE LA CRUZ:

(assuring him)

Well, you seem to have done a good job with your sister. And from what I've heard, you had one hell of a father. Raised you and your sister alone after your mother passed, and taught you guys Filipino culture like no other.

(CARLOS looks hesitant to say anything)

NURSE:

Dr. De la Cruz, here is the Rivera's child from Room 338

DR. DELA CRUZ:

Thank you. Would you like to hold him?

CARLOS:

Yes, Doctor.— I mean, sure.

(CARLOS takes the baby and cradles him in his arms)

He's cute. He reminds me of my father a little.

DR. DE LA CRUZ:

The parents said they also want a second name, but you can decide that.

CARLOS:

Alejandro... Mario Alejandro. Doctor, could I have a moment alone with him?

(DR DE LA CRUZ leaves; CARLOS takes a deep breath and then looks up to the sky)

Tay... is this your way of telling me something? I don't think I'm ready, but when I look at him, I think of you, I think of home, I think of Alejandro... I don't want this child to grow up without his culture, Tay. He's Filipino, he's like me. He's a blank slate, pero Pilipino pa rin siya (he's still Filipino). When I have enough money, I'll return, Tay. When he's old enough, I'll show him the dances, the mango tree, the Barkada, my Alejandro...

I promise, I'll go back...

(cradle the baby)

I'll take care of him, like I took care of Isabella... like you took care of me. Bye bye, Tay. I love you.

SCENE VII: Letters

Letter 1 - 2001 Mario Alejandro 1 year old

AJ:

Guys, it's a letter from Carlos.

LENA:

Finally he writes back.

BENJI:

Finally he learned how to write.

REYNA:

No teasing our friends while they're away. Only while they're here.

AJ:

Okay, here we go.

My dearest Alejandro.

I wanted to start by apologizing for not having been in touch since I left home. After my dad passed away a couple years ago, I did anything to distract myself away from his death: work, Isabella, . I'm a full time nurse at St. Joseph's Medical Hospital, which means I have no more me time...no more free time...no more Filipino time. There's a lot of new people coming into my life, so I can't afford to clock in late anymore. I just have so much on my plate right now, and I miss the Philippines. I miss the tree we used to play under...I miss getting taho with Reyna, Benji, and Lena... I miss dancing together...before I had to leave and start a new life in America. But trust me, I will never forget any of it. I promise my love for the Philippines still runs deep, and I promise I will keep more in touch.

Your pogi boy,
Carlos

Letter 2 - 2006 Mario Alejandro 6 year old

My dearest, Alejandro...

Thank you for the postcard from home; it really meant a lot and it made me think. Despite everyone being busy with their jobs and taking care of their families now, I know that you and the barkada do your best to keep in touch. After all, Lena can't chismis by herself.

On another note, I wanted to open up about something that I've kept out of our letters these past couple years. I'm not too sure why I kept this a secret for so long—maybe I was just afraid that telling you would mean that my stay in America was permanent.

I've included a picture of me and my son, Mario Alejandro Santos, at his 5th birthday party. He reminds me a lot about you... after all, he's an Alejandro. While I had help from Isabella and her husband on special occasions, it wasn't easy raising him as a single father. No help changing his diapers every night, no late night with someone to keep me company. No one really heard me when I needed to get something off my chest.

PS, I'm planning to come back on April 20. I'll be there for 2 weeks. Let's get together with the barkada. And let's get coffee some time, tayong dalawa, just the two of us.

See you soon, guapito. Landi landi ka dyan, baka bigla kang madapa.

As always, your pogi boy,
Carlos

SCENE VIII: Pamana

[ISABELLA, CARLOS, and MARIO JR enter from stage left with MARIO JR looking around in amazement of the stories his father told him coming to life. CARLOS and ISABELLA follow him.]

MARIO JR:

(taking in everything with wide eyes)

Dad, it's so alive! Everything's moving, and breathing!

CARLOS:

Just like your Lolo described it in stories, 'di ba, anak?

ISABELLA:

(breathing deeply)

It still smells like fresh pandesal and smog.

[A street vendor passes by selling taho]

:

TAHO! TAHO! TAHO!

MARIO JR:

(excited)

Dad! Taho! Like in your stories about you and Tito AJ! Can I have one?

(Carlos gives Mario a peso to get Taho from)

CARLOS:

(softly to ISABELLA)

I told him that every morning before school, Alejandro would always save half for me, even when I was running late.

(MARIO JR comes back)

MARIO JR:

Dad, can we explore? I want to see everything! The school, the tree —

CARLOS:

Anak, we're here. This is the mango tree.

ISABELLA:

Our Lolo used to pick us up from school right here.

CARLOS:

And your Tita Isabella used to sprain her ankle on that dip in the ground.

[ISABELLA playfully punches her brother]

ISABELLA:

And you always used to flirt with AJ on that bench.

MARIO JR:

You didn't tell me that story about Tito AJ, Tay!

CARLOS:

I'll tell you another time.

[CARLOS shushes ISABELLA]

ISABELLA:

(jokingly pointing behind the tree)

Do you think AJ is gonna pop out from right behind there like usual?

CARLOS:

Actually, not today. He said he's away for a work trip. But I think, the rest of the barkada are on— (their way here now)

[REYNA, LENA, and BENJI enter stage right]

REYNA:

(acting stern, but actually emotional)

Carlos Santos! Twenty years and not one video call? Letters are romantic and all, but come on!

LENA:

(acting scolding, but through happy tears)

Let him breathe, Reyna! He just got here! Hala, you must be Mario Alejandro!
(hugging him tightly)

BENJI:

Woah, Lena let him breathe. Who is this kid anyway?

REYNA:

(playfully hitting BENJI)

Be quiet Paquito Diaz, that's Carlos's son!

[They all laugh, the sound echoing with memories.]

CARLOS:

(to his friends)

I've missed you all so much. Every day, I'd think about our spot under the tree, our dances, our dreams...

LENA:

(softly)

Don't worry, Carlos. We visit every month when we can.

BENJI:

And we even bring our kids. If I knew Carlos was bringing his son, I would've brought little Maribel.

REYNA:

If I hear you talk about your little Maribel one more time. I'm going to have Florencia teach you a lesson.

MARIO JR:

Oh, I know now, Tay. You're Tita Reyna, and you're Tito Benji, and you're Tita Lena. Dad always told me how Tita Reyna would hit Tito Benji every time he made a bad joke.

BENJI:

Wait...

(turns to CARLOS)

you thought my jokes were bad?

LENA:

And how about you, Isabella? How are you now? Do you have a boyfriend?

ISABELLA:

I actually just got married last year. I wish he could be here to meet you all, but he's attending a conference in Los Angeles, so he couldn't make it.

REYNA:

OMG, is he pogit? Or is he putit?

[ISABELLA shows REYNA photos her phone]

LENA:

Anyways, you didn't tell us how guapo your son is. How old are you now, little Mario Alejandro?

MARIO JR:

I'm 8 years old now po.

LENA:

Edi wow, "po". So respectful, Mario. You taught him well.

CARLOS:

Just following after my father. His family gave him up for adoption at a young age, and I wanted to make sure he kept in touch with his Filipino side.

LENA:

Your dad would've been proud.

REYNA:

Isabella and I are going to get a drink and chika chika for a bit, her husband is apparently a model on the side. (turns to ISABELLA) So, does he have any friends?

[REYNA, and ISABELLA exit stage left]

BENJI:

I'll show him our elementary school.

[BENJI, MARIO JR., exit stage right]

LENA:

Kumusta ka, Carlos? Sa totoo?

CARLOS:

It's been hard. Walking around this neighborhood again, I've just been reminded of my dad—the old house, the mangos, the airport.

LENA:

I get it. Old memories resurface...Nevermind that, is there anyone else it's reminded you of? I'm surprised you haven't asked about him.

CARLOS:

He said he's not in town while I'm here. I was really hoping to see him and ask how he's been doing.

[AJ enters stage left]

LENA:

Well...why don't you ask him yourself.

[LENA motions stage left]

LENA:

(to AJ while walking toward stage left)

He's all yours.

[LENA exits stage left]

[CARLOS stands frozen]

CARLOS:

(barely a whisper)

Hindi ako makapaniwala. **[TRANSLATION: "I can't believe it"]** You're here.

[They hug]

AJ:

Hi, Pogi Boy.

(smirks)

[Silence as they both stare at each other]

Don't tell me you forgot your nickname for me.

CARLOS:

Of course, not. I could never forget my guapito– I mean, you, guapito. Just guapito.

AJ:

Just as awkward as ever. You haven't changed one bit, Carlos.

CARLOS:

I mean, what else hasn't? The tree's still standing.. (beat)

[CARLOS notices something on the tree]

AJ:

Our little note to each other is still here...

(touches a faded marking on the trunk)

CARLOS:

(tracing the carving)

"C & A, forever."

Alejandro, can I— (ask you something?)

AJ:

Let me guess, you wanna ask if you can tell me something?

CARLOS:

Fine, I'm just gonna say it... I've missed you. Not a day went by where I didn't think of you. Of us...

AJ:

Could I ask something now? You said I'm gonna miss you the day before you left for America...did you mean that?

CARLOS:

Of course, I meant that—

AJ:

I mean...did you mean *that*? or did you mean to say something else?

CARLOS:

Obviously, I was gonna miss you, I was always gonna miss you. No matter where you went, I wasn't going to stop caring about you. You're my best friend. And as I've grown up, I've realized... you've always been more than that.

[A beat of stunned silence. AJ looks at CARLOS's face, his own emotions surfacing.]

AJ:

I was wondering when you'd finally say it.

[CARLOS blinks in surprise, caught off guard by AJ's response.]

CARLOS:

Say what?

AJ:

You dummy, I've been your best friend since we were in primary school. When we went to college, we danced. And we felt like we were in "forever". And then just like that we were apart. I felt like one half of me was missing. A half of me that no one else could have replaced... and I finally know why, I just needed you to say it.

CARLOS:

I love you, Alejandro.

AJ:

I love you too, Carlos.

[REYNA bursts in first, followed by LENA, BENJI, ISABELLA, and MARIO JR.]

REYNA:

(clapping)

Finally you two.

LENA:

(clapping)

Couldn't have done it anywhere better.

BENJI:

I was just about to buy popcorn.

MARIO JR:

He really was, Tay!

ISABELLA:

And the crowd goes wild.

[They all laugh]

CARLOS:

Yeah, yeah... *(sigh)* do you guys remember my dad's analogy about the tree? He said childhood friends are like the roots of this old tree; even when you can't see them, they're always connected.

AJ:

You never forgot about us. Even when we were 8,000 miles away, you managed to come back.

ISABELLA:

And with a new family to pass down your culture to.

CARLOS:

Ah, that reminds me, anak. This is your Tito AJ, your Tito Alejandro. I named you after him because he meant so much to me, and I'm happy I did.

AJ:

Hello little one.

MARIO JR:

Nice to meet you original Alejandro!

CARLOS:

Without Alejandro or my dad, or any of you, I would have never become the person I am. Remember pamana, anak? And what I said about legacy?.

(Turn to friends)

I was telling him it's not just the names or stories we give to our children, it's the memories we make along the way, the friends and the community who hold us down and push us into the future. It's like making space for the good things to come, while treasuring and remembering the friends we left behind. Mario Alejandro, anak, you are my Pamana. You all are.

(Everyone hugs)

END